# Severe Institutional Deprivation Is Not Ordinary Parenting

*Randomized foster-care placement after early institutional care improves some cognitive and relational outcomes; the contrast is severe deprivation, not typical variation in sensitivity or daycare.*

**MODERATE-TO-HIGH-PLACEMENT; VERY-LOW-ORDINARY-CARE | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: ATTACHMENT, REGULATION, SOCIAL |**

## WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Severe early institutional deprivation can impair cognitive, socioemotional, and physical development. In the Bucharest Early Intervention Project, abandoned children already living in institutions were randomly assigned to high-quality foster care or care as usual. Family placement improved cognitive outcomes relative to remaining institutionalized; recovery was incomplete and depended on timing and stability. This is a deprivation-versus-family-care contrast, not a study of ordinary parental inconsistency.

## EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Nelson, Zeanah, Fox et al. (2007), Science: 136 institutionalized children randomized; cognitive outcomes through 54 months were higher in the foster-care arm, especially among the youngest placed. A later overview (Nelson, Fox & Zeanah, 2023/2024) summarizes follow-ups through adolescence: benefits in several domains, incomplete recovery, and timing effects that the authors describe as possible sensitive periods for this deprivation package. Random assignment is unusually strong for this question; the Romanian institutional conditions of the trial (rotating caregivers, low stimulation, bundled health and nutritional risk) do not represent ordinary parenting.

## EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

Group differences are large relative to never-institutionalized community comparisons and smaller, still meaningful, for foster care versus care as usual. Persistence is domain-specific; some advantages remain, others do not fully close. Placement stability matters. These are not portable “attachment treatment” effect sizes.

## BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (randomized foster-placement intervention following severe deprivation, not ordinary parenting).

The intervention is a package (stable caregivers, stimulation, nutrition, health, material support). Isolating “attachment” from the rest is not licensed. Attrition and later placement changes complicate long follow-up. Ethical and historical uniqueness limits generalization.

## WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Ordinary parental mistakes, ordinary daycare, or ordinary variation in sensitivity do not equal institutional deprivation. Early adversity does not make recovery impossible. The Strange Situation is not a personality test derived from this trial.

## WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Prevent severe neglect and unnecessary institutionalization; provide stable family-based care. Using BEIP to rank typical parents is not justified.

### VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Nelson, Zeanah, Fox, Marshall, Smyke & Guthrie (2007), Science 318:1937–1940
- Nelson, Fox & Zeanah (2023/2024), Current Directions in Psychological Science (PMC10977996)